a terrible experience when he went to drop his sister on a date. "I usually accompany her on dates to ensure safety," he says. "When we reached the meeting point outside the Noida metro in Sector 50, there were four men in a car and the phone we were messaging on was with them. The person whose profile my sister had seen never existed. Thankfully, we realised in time and exited the scene. But after this, neither of us uses apps anymore. It's better to meet someone through work, friends or family."

Taking note of such pitfalls, many apps are now using Artificial Intelligence to enhance the safety features. Bumble, for example, has made several AI-based additions this year, among them a new AI-driven system that automatically prioritises the most severe safety reports and shortens response time. AI is also used to identify potential violations of community guidelines on the app. A blue shield on profile photos now indicates they have undergone Bumble's AI verification process. The app's Deception Detector, meanwhile, uses AI to help identify spam, scam and fake profiles before people even see them. The model uses machine learning to assess profile authenticity. A Private Detector first detects, then blurs any lewd or nude images and alerts the recipient who can choose to view, delete or report the image.

There are other ways apps are using AI to help love blossom. ChatGPT, for instance, has come to their aid to devise questions on what matters to a person on dates—from what you value most in a partner to how you can balance your own needs with the needs of a partner.

But apps may just be overdoing things. "You cannot expect technology to foster human relationships," says serial dating app user Rushali Varma, 26, who works at an IT firm in Bengaluru. "It doesn't have human emotions and it cannot understand them no matter how much data you feed." She also feels constantly answering questions about relationships is tedious and feels completely fake. "I don't think we need to give an exam to meet someone. When I began using apps four years ago, there wasn't so much of a push to make you meet the right person. You trusted your own judgement and went ahead. Safety was ensured, the rest was your luck." What Rushali does appreciate is apps promoting safe offline meet-ups.

Highly specialised and niche dating apps are also thriving. Gleeden, an app available only to married couples looking for a relationship outside marriage, now has the maximum share of its users from India—a staggering two million. Other apps like Feeld, Amoure, Fondhope have widened the field, especially since the decriminalisation of adultery in 2018. "Open marriages involve consensual romantic or sexual interactions outside the primary partnership," says Shivani Misri Sadhoo, psychologist and marriage counsellor, Delhi.



***"OkCupid is the only dating app in the world that matches people* ON WHAT MATTERS *to them through* IN-APP QUESTIONS. *These are about everything that is important to* MILLENNIAL *and* GEN Z DATERS, *like* CLIMATE CHANGE *and* REPRODUCTIVE RIGHTS"**

MICHAEL KAYE
Director, Brand Marketing & Communications, OKCupid

BY INVITE ONLY APPS

For the more discerning, there are invite-only apps. Among them is Raya, an exclusive, private, membership-based app, allegedly used by celebrities including Janhvi Kapoor, Vaani Kapoor, Channing Tatum, Trevor Noah and Joe Jonas. Says a user who does not wish to be named: "I come from a business family and, at the end of the day, I need to be seen with a woman from a certain socio-economic background. My family won't accept less. In Raya, there is a high degree of control over who can join. I have been on 6-7 dates and they have all gone well. One has turned into a serious relationship. I'd say this is an app that is a free equivalent to traditional high-profile arranged marriages."

Catering to the desire to date someone who shares your interests are apps based on specific interests—food, entertainment, politics, social outlook. So, you have Turn up for music enthusiasts, Jalebi for Gen Z users, Gluten-free Singles and Veggly for those with dietary issues, and even community based apps such as Neetho for Telugus, or Farmers, an app only for those who own farmland.

A study commissioned by Bumble and conducted by research consultants Censuswide in November 2023 involving over 2,000 Indians aged 18-40 across 10 cities, also revealed that singles today seek partners who not only care about social causes but also actively engage in them. "I think this is a step forward," says Prakriti Sharma, 33, a teacher in Pune. "That apps are realising it isn't just a person's intention that matters but what they do with it. I can say I want to help animals but if I just say it and not actually engage with it, then that is not actually a real connect. I think niche apps based around demonstrable interests are excellent."

But will it be enough to counter dating app fatigue? Will children of the digital age ever give in to the belief that perhaps matches are made in heaven, not on an app? That there is such a thing as serendipity? The answers may not be on ChatGPT. ■